



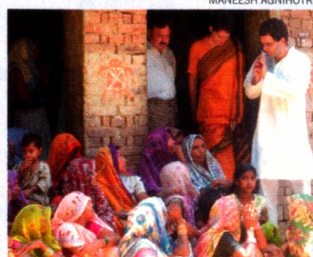
GEN NEXT: Older Congressmen can't keep pace with the youth icon

TIME OFF: It's not all khadi for Rahul, seen here at a cricket match



A tech freak, Rahul has recommended wooing new recruits through SMS and e-mail. He likes to shock ticket seekers with data—from his laptop—such as the number of mobile users in their constituency.

DILIP BANERJEE



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

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Number of states he has visited since he became an MP in 2004. He has campaigned in four.

'I'm basically doing the groundwork right now. I have to look into the status of things.'

AT A CRICKET MATCH BETWEEN NSUI AND THE YOUTH CONGRESS, HE OPTED TO FIELD FOR BOTH TEAMS. THE QUESTION IS, WHEN WILL HE START BATTING?

Symbolically enough, he is a member of the Congress Committee on Future Challenges, along with other young MPs like Sandeep Dikshit, Pilot and Jyotiraditya Scindia. Within the party, this is also known as Rahul's think-tank. Chaired by Veerappa Moily, it has Digvijay Singh and Prithviraj Chavan to mentor him. Moily, however, never sits at the head of the table. All of them sit facing one another on either side of it. After all, they know who the real boss is. When Anand Sharma began speaking of the challenges before the party, he was politely corrected by Rahul and asked to use "opportunities" instead of "chal-



GET SET GO: He may not get full marks for performance but he is trying

lenges". Wordplay aside, the committee is now ready to present its first report to Sonia. The report focuses on Rahul's favourite theme of encouraging inner-party democracy and suggests making the Congress a cadre-based party. "He is keen on restructuring the social mix of the party," says Salman Khursheed, a committee member.

He is a member of the publicity committee too. His colleagues say he has repeatedly emphasised the need to market Brand Congress. No sooner did he suggest that the publicity pamphlets be prepared in bullet points instead of lengthy discourses that no one bothers to read, than General Secretary Digvijay's office was littered with pamphlets on the party's stand on Ram Sethu and reservations—all in bullet points. Apart from the superficial suggestions on presentation, till date, the Congress does not know what Rahul's stand on the issue of reservations is. Does he support it like his mother, or does he agree with his father, who had taken one look at the Mandal Commission report before asking G. Parthasarathy to find the most decrepit cupboard in the PMO and stow the file in it? Does Rahul favour going ahead with the Ram Sethu? What are his views on minority appeasement? So far, his political utterances have either invoked the past—absolving his father of all blame in the Babri Masjid demolition, for instance—or referred to Uttar Pradesh. He clearly does not feel the need to elaborate any moreright now.

Rahul has read the nuclear deal, but is he ready to sacrifice the Government for it? Like his great-grandfather, he has a penchant for foreign affairs and loves reading books on national security. According to a Union minister, given a choice between finance and foreign affairs he would chose the latter—and no puns intended, he added.

He may not get full marks for performance, but at least he is trying. He knows that a Gandhi will be a prime ministerial candidate even if he did not undertake the discovery-of-India tours. For all his naive pronouncements, there is a bluntness about him. He is careful not to